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IN THE UNITED STATES DISTRICT COURT

FOR THE DISTRICT OF HAWAII

STUDENTS FOR FAIR ADMISSIONS, *Plaintiff,* v. TRUSTEES OF THE ESTATE OF BERNICE PAUAHI BISHOP d/b/a KAMEHAMEHA SCHOOLS, *Defendant.*	Civil No. 1:25-cv-00450 **COMPLAINT**

1. Kamehameha Schools—the wealthiest, elite, prestigious private school in Hawaii—admits to giving a "preference" to "applicants of Hawaiian ancestry." Far more than a "preference," Kamehameha admits zero students who lack native Hawaiian ancestry. It considers non-natives only if, after accepting all native Hawaiians, it still has open seats—a condition that Kamehameha makes sure never holds.

2. A preference for native Hawaiians is "race-based." *Rice v. Cayetano*, 528 U.S. 495, 517 (2000). Admission to private school, including one that gets no federal funds, involves contracts. *Runyon v. McCrary*, 427 U.S. 160, 168 (1976). And racial discrimination in contracting is illegal under 42 U.S.C. §1981. That the discrimination follows a princess's will is no defense to §1981, any more than when another part of her will (that all teachers be Protestant) was deemed illegal under Title VII. *EEOC v. Kamehameha Sch.*, 990 F.2d 458, 466 & n.18 (9th Cir. 1993).

3. Kamehameha's race-based admissions policy has been challenged under §1981 before. In an 8-7 decision, the Ninth Circuit agreed that the policy is race-based and contractual, but upheld it under §1981's supposed "affirmative action" exception. *Doe v. Kamehameha Sch.*, 470 F.3d 827 (9th Cir. 2006) (en banc) ("*Doe I*"). Though Kamehameha temporarily won by a single vote, it was not confident in its victory. On the eve of the Supreme Court's decision to grant certiorari, Kamehameha paid that child's family $7 million to drop the case ($10.5 million, in today's dollars).

4. No amount of money could make Kamehameha's admissions policy lawful. The time has come for its blood-based discrimination to end. Nothing about training future leaders, or preserving Hawaii's unique culture, requires Kamehameha to block its students from learning beside children of different ancestries—Asian, black, Hispanic, or white. Segregation is bad. *Brown v. Bd. of Ed.*, 347 U.S. 483, 494 (1954). "Separate cannot be equal." *SFFA v. Harvard*, 600 U.S. 181, 203 (2023). And "[t]he time for making distinctions based on race" in education has "passed." *Id.* at 204.

5. While the Ninth Circuit's 8-7 decision was wrong in 2006, it certainly cannot shield Kamehameha today. Its legal reasoning was abrogated by the Supreme Court in *Harvard*. And its factual reasoning is stale: Per the Ninth Circuit, Kamehameha has an ongoing duty to justify its use of race with "current" data, and to use race "only for so long as is necessary"—conditions that, now 20 years later, Kamehameha cannot satisfy. 470 F.3d at 846. If the Ninth Circuit meant to exempt Kamehameha from satisfying those conditions by carving it out of §1981 entirely, then that carveout is unconstitutional.

6. Kamehameha's race-based admissions policy is illegal. It continues to harm families, like SFFA's members, whose children cannot fairly compete for admission because they were born in the wrong family tree. This Court should order Kamehameha to desegregate with all deliberate speed.

PARTIES

7. Plaintiff, Students for Fair Admissions, is a voluntary membership organization formed for the purpose of defending human rights and civil liberties, including the right to be free from illegal racial discrimination, through litigation and other lawful means. SFFA and its members believe that racial preferences in school admissions are unfair, unnecessary, and illegal. SFFA is recognized by the IRS as a 501(c)(3) tax-exempt nonprofit.

8. SFFA is a traditional, genuine membership association. Founded in 2014, SFFA has grown to over 19,000 members. SFFA has vindicated many members' rights in many federal cases, including its successful litigation against Harvard and UNC. *See Our Cases*, SFFA, studentsforfairadmissions.org/our-cases.

9. SFFA brings this lawsuit in a representational capacity on behalf of its members who would have standing to sue on their own. All of SFFA's standing members voluntarily joined the organization, support its mission, authorized SFFA to represent their rights in this case, receive updates and can give input and direction on this case, and are represented by SFFA in good faith.

10. Defendant, Trustees of the Estate of Bernice Pauahi Bishop d/b/a Kamehameha Schools, is a system of private schools in Hawaii. It is a 501(c)(3) tax-exempt nonprofit. It adopted and implements the race-based admissions policy at issue here.

JURISDICTION & VENUE

11. Subject-matter jurisdiction exists under 28 U.S.C. §1331 because this case arises under 42 U.S.C. §1981, a federal statute.

12. Venue is proper under 28 U.S.C. §1391(b) because all defendants reside here and Kamehameha administers the challenged policy here.

BACKGROUND

I. Kamehameha Schools uses a racial preference in admissions that, in effect and by design, ensures only native Hawaiians are admitted.

13. Kamehameha Schools is the largest private landowner in Hawaii, with holdings spanning 364,000 acres. Kamehameha is also the largest educational trust in the country, with an endowment worth over $15 billion.

14. Kamehameha educates students from kindergarten through twelfth grade, plus preschoolers. Kamehameha has three campuses: Hawaii, Kapalama, and Maui.

15. Today, Kamehameha educates around 6% of the island's native Hawaiians—5,400 K-12 students (100% of whom are native Hawaiian) out of 86,000 school-aged native Hawaiians. When its policy was last challenged, Kamehameha educated around 7% of the island's native Hawaiians—4,800 K-12 students out of 70,000 school-aged native Hawaiians. *Doe I*, 470 F.3d at 832.

16. Kamehameha has no special-education program. Its rigorous admission standards exclude students with serious mental disabilities.

17. Admission to Kamehameha is highly "competitive." The number of children seeking admission has been "increasing" every year.

18. Whether and when children can apply depends on their zip code and age. Generally, students in preschool can apply for kindergarten; and students in grades 3, 6, 8, 9, 10, and 11 can apply for the next grade up. An applicant cannot apply for the same grade level in two consecutive years.

19. Kamehameha also allows "out-of-state applicants" to apply for grades 7-12.

20. For the 2025-26 school year, the application window opened on August 15 and closed on September 30, 2025.

21. To apply, parents use an online portal. Parents cannot use the portal unless they create an account. Creating an account requires parents to "read and agree to" the "Kamehameha Schools Access Agreement." This contract contains a choice-of-law provision and a forum-selection clause. The applicant must certify: "I am 18 years of age or older, or possess legal parental or guardian consent, and am competent to enter into this Agreement." The applicant must also agree that "any lawsuit or claim against KS arising from or related to this application must be brought exclusively in the U.S. District Court for the District of Hawaii or in the state courts of the State of Hawaii," and that any federal claims "shall be governed exclusively by the federal law applied by the U.S. District Court for the District of Hawaii."

22. After creating an account, parents must fill out a questionnaire. Students must also attend a test session on campus at Kamehameha and an in-person interview with Kamehameha staff.

23. To submit the application, parents must sign the "Acknowledge, Consent, and Authorization." Among other obligations, this contract requires parents to "waive, release, and hold harmless" Kamehameha for mishandling the information disclosed in the application. It also requires parents to "waive any rights" to privacy or publicity, including "photographs" of the child, and to give Kamehameha the right to "use" this information for its own purposes. The Acknowledge warns that it's a binding contract: "THE CONTENTS AND NATURE OF THIS AGREEMENT ARE CONTRACTUAL, NOT A MERE RECITAL," and applying parents "AGREE TO BE BOUND BY ALL TERMS AND CONDITIONS CONTAINED IN THIS AGREEMENT."

24. Once a child is accepted, that child cannot enroll at Kamehameha unless the parents sign the "Enrollment Contract/General Release." Among other binding obligations, this contract requires parents—"[i]n consideration for" Kamehameha supervising their child—to indemnify and waive their right to sue Kamehameha for certain injuries. It, too, stresses its contractual nature.

WHEREFORE, Plaintiff asks this Court to enter judgment in its favor and to provide the following relief:

a. A declaratory judgment that Kamehameha's race-based admissions policy violates §1981.

b. A permanent injunction prohibiting Kamehameha from knowing or considering applicants' race, including their native Hawaiian ancestry, when making admissions decisions.

c. A declaratory judgment that Kamehameha must take all steps "necessary and proper" to desegregate "with all deliberate speed." *Brown v. Bd. of Educ.*, 349 U.S. 294, 301 (1955).

d. Any equitable relief needed to undo Kamehameha's past discrimination, including an order barring Kamehameha from applying its rules governing the timing of applications or the location of applicants to past victims.

e. Reasonable costs and expenses of this action, including attorneys' fees.

f. All other relief that Plaintiff is entitled to, including nominal damages of $1 for each standing member's lost opportunity to apply.

Dated: October 20, 2025

Respectfully submitted,

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